INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #52 · FORGIVING OTHERS

“Forgiving means I have to trust them again.”

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Where it often comes from

Many believers were taught that real forgiveness means returning to how things were. In families, churches, and marriages, people are sometimes pressured to resume relationships with those who have not changed. That can lead us either to refuse forgiveness or to return to harm.

What Scripture teaches

Forgiveness and trust are different. Forgiveness is a gift we give; trust is something earned. Proverbs says, “The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps.” Jesus told His disciples, “Be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves.” He also said, “If he repents, forgive him,” which is about forgiveness, not about instantly resuming a close relationship. Paul writes, “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone,” which acknowledges that peace is sometimes not possible. Where there is danger, safety must come first.

> *“The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps”* (Proverbs 14:15).

Also see

> “Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves” (Matthew 10:16).

> “Watch yourselves. If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him. Even if he sins against you seven times in a day, and seven times returns to say, ‘I repent,’ you must forgive him” (Luke 17:3–4).

> “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone” (Romans 12:18).

> “Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you” (Ephesians 4:32).

Common self-statements

- If I forgive, I have to let them back in.
- Forgiving means going back to normal.
- I cannot forgive because I cannot trust.
- If I keep my distance, I have not truly forgiven.
- I have to give another chance.
- I owe them access to me.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must forgive and trust fully, or neither.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should return to the relationship.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that if I forgive, I will be hurt again.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling unsafe and concluding that I cannot forgive.

Challenging questions

- What is the difference between forgiveness and trust in my own words?
- Has the person changed, taken responsibility, and shown consistency?

- What conditions would make trust possible?
- What boundaries do I need to stay safe?
- Is there danger I need to take seriously?
- How can I forgive and still protect myself?

Truth summary

> I can forgive without trusting. Forgiveness releases the debt; trust is rebuilt over time through changed behavior. I can set wise boundaries, even limit contact, and still obey God in forgiving.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Trust
- Wisdom
- Protection
- Divorce

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Anger

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "Forgiving means I have to trust them again"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Forgiving means I have to trust them again." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the difference between forgiveness and trust?
- ☐ What would show change?
- ☐ What boundary do I need?
- ☐ Is there danger?
- ☐ Who can help?
- ☐ How can I forgive and stay safe?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness is not the same as trust.
- ☐ Trust is earned by changed behavior.
- ☐ The prudent watch their steps.
- ☐ I can forgive and keep boundaries.
- ☐ Safety comes first.
- ☐ Peace is not always possible.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 14:15**
  "The simple man believes every word, but the prudent man watches his steps."
- ☐ **Matthew 10:16**
  "Behold, I am sending you out like sheep among wolves; therefore be as shrewd as snakes and as innocent as doves."
- ☐ **Romans 12:18**
  "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone."

A verse I found myself: _____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Forgiven and protected: Each week, note one boundary that protects you and one release of resentment.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Proverbs 14:15 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can forgive and still be wise about trust.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List the difference. Write forgiveness on one side and trust on the other.
- ☐ Define the evidence. Write what changes would be needed to trust again.
- ☐ Set the boundary. Decide what contact is safe.
- ☐ Seek help if unsafe. If there is abuse, call 911 or the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Forgiving means I have to trust them again": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Forgiven and protected
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Forgiving means I have to trust them again.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, help me forgive without putting myself at risk. Teach me wisdom about trust and give me courage to keep healthy boundaries. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.